▼ VIEWPOINT

STAMPING OUT STAMPEDES

Frequent stampedes expose critical gaps in planning, policing and preparedness across India's crowded public spaces



BY ABHINAV KUMAR

In nearly three decades of service in the police force, one has come to understand that public order and safety hinge upon both past experience and continuous innovation. In India, a land of immense diversity and vibrant public gatherings, the frequency of stampedes is a recurring challenge, demanding our unwavering attention and proactive measures.

Over the past five years, more than two dozen stampedes have been reported from all parts of the country. These are mostly triggered during religious festivals and large-scale public events. Each incident, whether during a cultural celebration or an unexpected rush, serves as a sombre reminder of the critical gaps in our crowd management strategies and state capacity. What remains evident is that our approach must evolve, and so must our leadership at every level of the police hierarchy—especially when incidents such as the June 4 stampede in Bengaluru remind us of the human cost of inadequate planning and response.

This year alone, Andhra Pradesh, Goa, Delhi and Uttar Pradesh have seen stampede-related deaths. On that fateful day in Bengaluru, the stampede not only took the lives of many citizens and devastated their grieving families, but also laid bare the vulnerabilities within our operational protocols. While the state government has taken action against the police leadership, and a judicial inquiry has been ordered, all those who pushed the police leadership into agreeing to this event at less than 12 hours' notice without proper planning or preparation must also be held accountable.

Reflecting on that incident, several lessons must be embraced by police leadership across the country. First, it is essential to adopt crowd management strategies that are constantly updated. Detailed preparations that include clear demarcation of entry and exit points, setting up physical barriers and deploying adequate personnel to oversee crowd flow are non-negotiable. Strategic planning informed by past experiences will enable us to anticipate challenges even before they fully manifest.

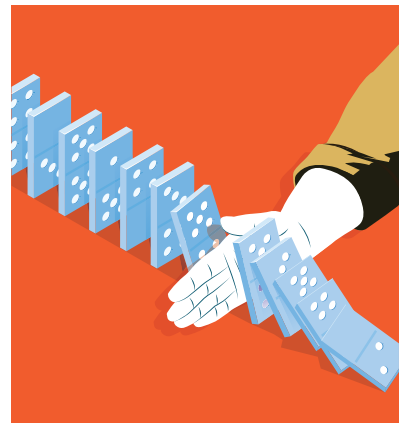


Illustration by RAJ VERMA

BESIDES BOLSTERING POLICE LEADERSHIP, TECHNOLOGY CAN BE LEVERAGED TO MAKE OUR APPROACH THOROUGHLY PROACTIVE

Another critical lesson is the imperative of rigorous training and preparedness. The unpredictable nature of stampedes demands that every officer, especially those on the front lines, participates in realistic drills and simulations. Such exercises are crucial in preparing teams for high-pressure situations, ensuring that decisions can be made swiftly and decisively. We must foster a culture where our officers are not only skilled in routine operations but are also well-prepared to handle emergencies with calm and precision.

Technological integration is another area where we have opportunities to improve. Modern advancements in communication and surveillance, including the use of drones and real-time analytics, can enhance situational awareness during peak events. As police officers, leveraging these technologies can firmly shift our approach from being reactionary to becoming thoroughly proactive. Synergy among law enforcement, emergency responders and event organisers is imperative for the smooth organisation of all such events.

Public cooperation remains a cornerstone of effective crowd management. Educating citizens on how to remain composed during unforeseen emergencies must be prioritised. Through comprehensive public awareness campaigns, we can equip the community with the necessary knowledge to navigate crowded spaces safely, turning potential chaos into organised safety.

In conclusion, the distressing frequency of stampedes in India compels us to introspect, adapt and strengthen our public order strategies. The lessons drawn from the Bengaluru stampede should become a catalyst for change—a call to police leadership to re-examine our protocols, bolster our training and invest in technology and community relations. That will be a fitting tribute to the victims and their grieving families. ■

The author is a serving IPS officer. Views are personal